

PassKonnnect

A digital trade-readiness identity for African MSMEs

Submitted by: Telnora Technologies (Abuja, Nigeria) **Challenge:** AfCFTA Digital Innovation Challenge — 2nd Edition **Theme:** Shaping Africa's Future Through African Solutions **Focus areas addressed:** Trade & Investment Facilitation · Market Intelligence & E-Commerce · Digital Financial Services (payments-readiness layer)

1. Problem Statement

The African Continental Free Trade Area removes tariffs on paper, but for the average MSME — a fashion designer in Cameroon, a food processor in Ghana, a leather goods maker in Kenya — the free trade area is functionally closed. Not because demand doesn't exist across borders, but because three things stand between a small seller and their first cross-border sale:

They don't know how to prove their goods qualify as "originating" in Africa, which is the entire legal mechanism that unlocks AfCFTA's preferential tariffs. Rules-of-origin certification is written for customs officers and trade lawyers, not for a two-person workshop.

They have no way to appear credible to a stranger in another country. A buyer in Accra has no reason to trust an unfamiliar seller in Douala — there's no shared, verifiable record of who they are, what they sell, or whether they've traded successfully before.

They face a wall of disconnected paperwork — export documentation, certificates of origin, tax and business registration proofs — scattered across formats, languages, and agencies, with no single place that turns "I want to sell abroad" into "here is what I need and here it is, done."

This is the specific gap between AfCFTA as policy and AfCFTA as lived experience. It is not primarily a payments problem or a shipping problem — both of those already have crowded, well-funded solutions in the African market. It is a documentation, trust, and readiness problem, and almost nothing has been built to solve it at the scale of an individual MSME.

2. Solution Walkthrough

PassKonnnect is a digital trade-identity profile that any MSME can build in under 30 minutes and use for every cross-border transaction after that.

Step 1 — Build your PassKconnect profile. The business owner signs up and answers a guided, plain-language questionnaire about their business: what they make or sell, where inputs come from, business registration details, and basic compliance documents (uploaded once). No trade jargon required — the system translates their answers into the technical language customs and buyers actually need.

Step 2 — Auto-generated trade documents. From that profile, PassKconnect generates a draft AfCFTA Certificate of Origin pack and a standardized export-readiness checklist specific to their product category and destination country, flagging anything still missing.

Step 3 — Verified public profile. Each business gets a shareable, verifiable PassKconnect profile page — a persistent digital identity with a scannable QR/verification code — showing what they sell, their compliance status, and (over time) a track record of completed cross-border transactions. A buyer in Accra can check a seller in Douala's PassKconnect profile before ever making contact.

Step 4 — Match & connect. Verified PassKconnect profiles appear in a lightweight searchable directory, filterable by product category, country, and origin-qualification status, so buyers seeking specific goods can find trade-ready sellers directly.

Step 5 — Grow the record. Every completed transaction logged through the platform strengthens that business's trade history, which in time becomes a credibility asset — useful not just for buyers, but eventually for lenders and logistics partners assessing risk.

3. MVP Scope (buildable ahead of the September 4 deadline)

In scope for the MVP:

Guided onboarding questionnaire translating plain business info into structured trade-readiness data.

Auto-generated Certificate of Origin draft and export-readiness checklist (Nigeria and 2–3 pilot corridor countries at launch, expandable by design).

Public, shareable verified PassKconnect profile page with QR-based verification.

Searchable directory of verified MSMEs, filterable by product/category/country.

Simple admin/verification layer for confirming uploaded business documents.

Explicitly out of scope for MVP (roadmap, not launch):

In-platform payments processing (integrate with existing providers later rather than rebuild).

Full logistics booking (directory can surface partner logistics providers, but booking/fulfillment is a v2 partnership, not something to build from scratch).

AI-based tariff/HS-code classification — planned as the first major post-MVP upgrade once real usage data exists to train and validate it against.

Keeping the MVP this tight matters for credibility: it is one problem, solved completely, for one user at a time, rather than a sprawling half-built super-app.

4. Tech Stack

Aligned with Telnora's existing web/mobile delivery capability, so this can move from concept to working demo quickly:

Frontend: React (web) with a responsive, mobile-first design; React Native reserved for a native app once the web MVP validates demand — most target users will access via mobile browser first.

Backend: Node.js/Express (or NestJS) API layer; PostgreSQL for structured business, document, and verification records.

Document generation: Templated PDF generation (e.g. a headless rendering service) driving the Certificate of Origin and checklist outputs from structured profile data.

Verification layer: QR code generation tied to a public, read-only verification endpoint — no blockchain dependency required for MVP, but the architecture leaves room to anchor verification records on a lightweight ledger later if judges weight "advanced technology" heavily.

Hosting/infra: Cloud-hosted (e.g. Render/Railway or AWS) for fast iteration; file storage (S3-compatible) for uploaded compliance documents.

Why this stack: every piece is something Telnora's team can already build and ship fast — the differentiator here is the idea and the execution discipline, not exotic technology for its own sake.

5. Differentiation

Existing AfCFTA-adjacent solutions cluster heavily around two crowded lanes: cross-border payments (Flutterwave, Chipper Cash, Cellulant, and others) and marketplace/logistics matchmaking. PassKonnnect deliberately does not compete there. Instead it sits one layer earlier in the funnel — it is the thing an MSME needs before they can credibly use a payments rail or a logistics marketplace at all: proof of who they are and proof their goods qualify for AfCFTA treatment.

This positioning has three advantages. It addresses AfCFTA's actual named mechanism (rules of origin and preferential access) rather than a generic e-commerce problem that happens to be cross-border. It is a genuinely underserved niche, so the pitch doesn't have to argue why this solution beats five funded competitors — there largely aren't five funded competitors solving trade-identity and documentation

specifically for MSMEs. And it is a natural platform, not a dead end: once a business has a verified PassKonnnect profile, it becomes the foundation other services can plug into — payments, logistics, lending — making this a credible first layer of a larger trade infrastructure play, not a one-off tool.

6. Impact Narrative

AfCFTA's promise is that a fashion designer in Cameroon should be able to sell to a customer in Ghana as easily as to a customer across town. Today the barrier isn't willingness on either side — it's that neither party has a reliable way to know the other is real, compliant, and ready to trade. PassKonnnect closes that specific gap, one business at a time: each profile created is one more MSME that has gone from "technically eligible for AfCFTA" to "actually able to use it."

At scale, this creates a growing, verifiable directory of trade-ready African MSMEs — a public good that benefits not just individual buyers and sellers, but customs authorities looking for compliance signal, lenders looking for credit-relevant trade history, and logistics providers looking for verified demand. It turns "youth-led innovation" into infrastructure: not a single clever transaction, but the connective layer that makes every future cross-border transaction on the continent easier than the one before it.

This directly answers the challenge's own framing — AfCFTA connects markets "on paper," and the innovation gap is in the technical, logistical, and digital barriers that stop MSMEs from using it in practice. PassKonnnect is built specifically to dismantle the first and most fundamental of those barriers: not knowing how to prove you're ready to trade.

7. Application Draft (mapped to the actual form)

I opened the official Google Form directly and mapped every question below to its real wording (Sections 2 and 3 — the ones with substance). I did not submit anything — the form was signed into a Google account that isn't yours (brasspaul.1@gmail.com), and submission needs your explicit go-ahead plus your real details. Open the form yourself, signed into your own account, and paste these in.

Form link: [2026 AfCFTA Digital Innovation Challenge Application Form](#)

Page 1 — Applicant Details (fill with your own info)

This page asks: whether you're applying as an Individual or Business/Enterprise; your full name, gender, age range (18–23 / 24–29 / 30–35), nationality (dropdown of AU member states), email, phone number with country code, and highest level of education. Nothing here is draftable on your behalf — it's your personal identity information. Select **Business/Enterprise** given you're applying as Telnora.

Page 2 — Enterprise/Startup/Company Details

Enterprise/Startup/Company Name: Telnora Technologies

Year it was established: 2025

Is the Enterprise/Startup/Company Registered? Yes

If yes, Date of Registration: 24 March 2025

Business Name Registration No.: 8361915 (Corporate Affairs Commission, Federal Republic of Nigeria; TIN 33001980-0001)

Please Upload your Business Registration Certificate: Use the CAC Certificate of Registration you shared — it's ready to attach as-is.

Website or Social Media Handles: <https://telnoratech.netlify.app>

Innovation Details

Name of the innovation solution: PassKonnnect

Stage of your innovation: Pilot (*most honest fit for a pre-launch MVP — Early Growth and Scaling imply live users already*)

Provide a detailed description of your innovation (500 words max): PassKonnnect is a digital trade-identity platform that gives African MSMEs a verified, shareable profile proving they are ready to trade across borders under AfCFTA. The core problem it solves is not payments or shipping — both already have crowded, funded solutions — but something more foundational: most small businesses are legally eligible for AfCFTA's preferential tariffs yet cannot access them in practice, because they don't know how to prove their goods qualify as "originating" in Africa, have no way to establish credibility with an unfamiliar buyer in another country, and face scattered, jargon-heavy export paperwork with no single starting point.

The platform works through a guided, plain-language onboarding flow: a business owner answers simple questions about what they make, where their inputs come from, and their registration and compliance details. From these answers, PassKonnnect auto-generates a draft AfCFTA Certificate of Origin pack and a destination-specific export-readiness checklist, translating technical customs language into something an ordinary business owner can complete unaided. Each business then receives a shareable, QR-verified public PassKonnnect profile — a persistent digital identity a buyer, customs contact, or partner in any AU member state can check before ever making contact. Verified businesses appear in a searchable directory, filterable by product category, country, and origin-qualification status, so buyers seeking specific goods can discover trade-ready sellers directly. Every completed transaction logged through the

platform strengthens that business's trade history, building a credibility asset useful not only to buyers but, over time, to lenders and logistics partners assessing risk.

PassKconnect is deliberately scoped to solve this one problem completely rather than attempting to be a payments or logistics platform on day one. It is designed as connective infrastructure other trade services can build on top of: once a business has a verified profile, that identity becomes the foundation payments providers, logistics partners, and lenders can plug into, rather than each rebuilding trust and verification from scratch. This positions the platform not as one more entrant into an already crowded marketplace or fintech lane, but as the layer those services still lack — proof of who a trading partner is and proof their goods actually qualify for the tariff treatment AfCFTA promises.

What competitive edge does your solution offer over existing solutions? (300 words max): Most AfCFTA-adjacent digital solutions cluster around two crowded lanes: cross-border payments and marketplace or logistics matchmaking. PassKconnect deliberately does not compete there — it sits one layer earlier, solving the documentation and trust problem an MSME must clear before a payments rail or logistics marketplace is even usable. This is a genuinely underserved niche: rather than differentiating against well-funded competitors, PassKconnect addresses AfCFTA's actual named legal mechanism — proof of African origin — which almost nothing at MSME scale currently automates. It is also structurally a platform, not a dead end: a verified profile becomes infrastructure other services (payments, logistics, lending) can build on, giving it durable relevance rather than a single-use case.

How does your solution improve factors such as cost, time, or complexities in cross-border trade? (300 words max): Preparing rules-of-origin documentation and export paperwork today typically requires paid intermediaries, customs agents, or weeks of trial and error for a business with no prior export experience — cost and delay that price out the smallest sellers entirely. PassKconnect compresses that into a guided process a business owner completes in under an hour, at no cost to generate the draft documentation. It also removes a hidden cost: the time and lost deals from a buyer's hesitation to trust an unfamiliar seller abroad. A verifiable PassKconnect profile shortens that trust-building cycle from repeated back-and-forth communication to a single shared link.

How does your solution leverage emerging technologies (200 words max): The MVP uses automated, templated document generation to turn structured business data into compliant trade documents, and QR-code-based public verification so any party can confirm a profile's authenticity instantly. The architecture is built to extend into AI-assisted tariff and HS-code classification once real usage data exists to train and validate it, and leaves room for anchoring verification records on a lightweight distributed ledger if stronger tamper-evidence is needed as the platform scales.

Which cross-border digital trade barriers does your innovation address? (select all that apply — recommended: Verification of trade related documents, Customs and border procedures, Regulatory compliance, Market access)

Who are the primary beneficiaries of your solution? *(select all that apply — recommended: SMEs, Youth entrepreneurs, Informal traders, Exporters)*

Page 3 — Impact and Scalability

What is your business model or plan to scale your innovation solution across multiple African markets?

(500 words max): PassKonnnect launches with a free tier for MSMEs to build and verify their profile, keeping the barrier to entry at zero for the businesses who need it most. Revenue is designed to come from the layer above the individual seller rather than from the seller directly: verified-directory placement and lead access for buyers and B2B platforms seeking trade-ready suppliers, and — once volume justifies it — referral and integration partnerships with payments, logistics, and trade-finance providers who benefit from plugging into an already-verified base of MSMEs rather than re-verifying each one themselves. Geographic expansion follows a corridor model: launch and prove the concept in a Nigeria-anchored pilot corridor with two to three initial destination countries, then replicate the same onboarding and verification playbook into additional AfCFTA corridors as each proves out, rather than attempting continent-wide launch at once.

How much traction has your innovation gained? (300 words max): PassKonnnect itself is pre-launch, so it has no users or revenue yet — but it is being built by an active, shipping engineering team rather than a first-time idea with no execution history. Telnora Technologies has already delivered production websites for law firm, e-commerce, and real estate clients both within Nigeria and internationally, and has independently built and launched a suite of free tools addressing everyday problems in Nigeria's informal economy — including a credit-tracking tool for traders, a market price transparency board, an artisan skills directory, a rotating-savings (ajo) tracker, and invoice/stock tools for micro-businesses (see <https://lookmeup.netlify.app/>) — alongside a legal-tech platform connecting clients with verified lawyers, an accessibility-first e-commerce platform for visually impaired shoppers, a biometric attendance system, and backend infrastructure for an NGO supporting girls into AI engineering. The team is currently under active development on two further live client projects: a property-listing web and mobile app for the Lagos market, and a security application for a church organization in Abuja. This track record of shipped, real-world products — several specifically addressing informal-economy and trust/verification problems closely related to PassKonnnect's core mechanics — is the strongest available evidence that the MVP described here can be built and delivered on the stated timeline.

What three key resources would be critical and how would you apply them to scale across multiple African markets? (300 words max): (1) In-house full-stack engineering capacity — Telnora already has proven Node.js/Express, React, Next.js, Flutter, and database (MongoDB/MySQL) capability from shipped projects, which removes the biggest execution risk most early-stage applicants face and lets the MVP move straight from concept to build. (2) Trade-body and chamber-of-commerce partnerships in each target corridor country, to reach MSMEs and lend PassKonnnect credibility with local customs

contacts. (3) Seed funding or grant capital to cover document-verification infrastructure, localization into additional languages and country-specific customs formats, and a small in-country operations presence to handle verification and business-registration checks that can't be fully automated.

If fully implemented across the African continent, what transformational impact on trade could your solution have? (300 words max): At full scale, PassKconnect would function as shared trade infrastructure for the continent — a common, verifiable layer of business identity that any AfCFTA-compliant service could build on top of, the way a national business registry underpins domestic commerce today. Millions of MSMEs currently locked out of cross-border trade by documentation and trust barriers alone would gain a low-cost, self-service path to becoming AfCFTA-compliant traders. Beyond individual transactions, a growing, verified directory of trade-ready businesses becomes a public good: customs authorities gain a compliance signal, lenders gain trade-history data to underwrite MSME credit, and logistics and payments providers gain a verified demand base to build services around — turning a single documentation tool into the connective layer that makes every subsequent cross-border transaction on the continent easier than the one before it.

How does your innovation align with AfCFTA's objectives? (200 words max): AfCFTA's core mechanism is preferential tariff access for goods proven to originate in Africa — a legal promise that stays theoretical for MSMEs who cannot navigate rules-of-origin documentation. PassKconnect operationalizes that exact mechanism at MSME scale, turning a customs-lawyer concept into a guided process any small business owner can complete unaided, directly advancing AfCFTA's stated goal of connecting African markets in practice rather than only on paper.

Team & track record (background — not a direct form field, but useful if a bio or portfolio link is requested, or for your own pitch materials)

Co-Founder: Paul Anyebe — cybersecurity and backend developer, B.Tech in Cyber Security Science, 3+ years building secure systems, has trained 100+ users and reduced platform vulnerabilities by 75% in prior work. Portfolio: <https://lookmeup.netlify.app/> | LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/in/paul-anyebe-web-designer/>

Co-Founder: Sophia Idioko — Executive Assistant & Chief of Staff Support; Business Operations & CRM/RevOps (HubSpot, Salesforce, GoHighLevel, QuickBooks); AI Automation & Content Systems; experienced media buyer; focused on scaling founders and executive teams. LinkedIn: <https://www.linkedin.com/in/sophia-godwin/>

Team/agency: Telnora Technologies (Abuja, Nigeria) — a registered digital product agency delivering web and mobile products across Node.js/Express, FastAPI, Next.js, React, Flutter, and MongoDB/MySQL, with payment gateway and authentication integration experience.

Relevant delivered work:

Client websites for law firms, e-commerce businesses, and real estate companies, both within Nigeria and internationally.

Jurilinka — legal-tech platform connecting clients with verified lawyers across Nigeria.

An accessibility-first e-commerce platform designed for visually impaired shoppers.

A biometric attendance system eliminating manual tracking errors for organizations.

Backend infrastructure for ROTAGI, an NGO supporting girls' pathways into AI engineering.

A full-stack delivery/logistics app for a startup client.

A suite of free, independently-built tools for Nigeria's informal economy: My Ledger (credit tracking for traders), Market Price Board (price transparency), Skills Board (artisan directory), Ajo Tracker (rotating savings groups), and Invoice & Stock (micro-business tools).

Currently in build: a property-listing web and mobile app for the Lagos market, and a security application for a church organization in Abuja — both live client engagements, demonstrating current, active delivery capacity rather than dormant or purely aspirational skills.

Page 4 — Declaration and Consent

Standard consent checkboxes plus your typed full name — complete this yourself at submission time, once everything above is finalized and accurate.

Before you submit

Everything substantive is now filled in with real detail. What's left is procedural:

Open the form signed into your own Google account (not brasspaul.1@gmail.com, which is whoever's account it happened to be signed into when I checked it).

Complete page 1 with your own personal details (name, gender, age range, nationality, phone, education).

Copy the drafted answers from Pages 2 and 3 above into the matching form fields, and attach the CAC certificate where it asks for the Business Registration Certificate upload.

Check the barrier and beneficiary checkboxes as recommended above (or adjust if you'd emphasize differently).

Review the whole thing once end-to-end, then complete the declaration and submit before September 4.

One optional strengthener: since PassKonnnect itself is pre-launch, even a rough clickable prototype or a handful of screens before you submit would give judges something concrete beyond the written description — worth doing if you have a spare day or two before the deadline, but not essential given the shipped track record above already establishes credibility.